the BJP–VHP cadres. He had a reputation of winning elections by big margins—he won the 2002 elections by 158,000 votes; he won the 2007 elections by an even more impressive 235,000 votes. ‘No one can touch Amitbhai in Sarkhej,’ was the unanimous verdict. Sarkhej was typically new Ahmedabad—middle class, commercial, and with a strong Hindu religious identity.

Born in a Vaishnav Vania orthodox Hindu family (he still visits the Shrinathji temple in Rajasthan’s Nathdwara at least twice a year), Shah had handled a successful family business in PVC pipes and had even dabbled in stockbroking like any financially sharp Gujarati. ‘His blue-chip stock portfolio is pretty impressive,’ one of Shah’s friends told me. But while his mind may have been counting the money, his heart was really in the RSS. He joined the Sangh in the early 1980s while still a teenager. ‘It was like my extended family,’ he told me once. ‘Being in the Sangh was the best thing that happened to me as a young man.’

Within the Sangh, Shah developed an image of an astute organizer and skilled election strategist. ‘Then, whether it was a garba function during Navaratra, a charity drive or a political meeting, when we needed to organize something in the area, we always turned to Amitbhai and he was always there for us,’ recalls an old colleague.

It was in the 1980s, while Shah was a Sangh activist, that he and Modi got to know each other. Modi, very much the senior leader, was impressed with Shah’s organizational skills and total commitment to the Hindutva ideology. The Ayodhya movement had begun to bubble, the BJP was a party on the rise in Gujarat, and Modi as state secretary was looking for young men with desire and ambition. ‘I think Modi liked the fact that Amitbhai was ready to do a lot of hard work silently without taking credit. He was not the kind who would challenge Modi’s authority at any stage,’ is how one Gujarati journalist explains the Shah–Modi chemistry. They both had strikingly similar looking beards as well!

When Modi was re-elected Gujarat chief minister in 2002, he gave Shah multiple portfolios, including the crucial home portfolio. The home ministry was critical because it gave Modi control over the police. In the backdrop of